



The Importance of Psychological Safety for Today's Member Board Community Workforce

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**Approximately how many
employees work at your board?**



What is your current work environment model?



Psychological safety (P.S.) is the shared belief that a team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking- that no one will be embarrassed, rejected, or penalized for speaking up. How would you rate P.S. at your organization? (1= little to no P.S., 5= high P.S.)



ABMS Member Boards Connect

The Importance of Psychological Safety for Today's Member Board Community Workforce

Christine Tierney, Vice President – Talent, Culture & Belonging, ABIM

Part 1: Why This Matters

Understanding the link between psychological safety, employee engagement, wellness, and team performance

What Is Psychological Safety?

The shared belief that a team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking — that no one will be embarrassed, rejected, or penalized for speaking up.

FOUR STAGES OF PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

1

Inclusion Safety

You feel welcomed and valued as part of the team

2

Learner Safety

You feel safe to ask questions, experiment, and make mistakes

3

Contributor Safety

You feel safe to use your skills and add real value

4

Challenger Safety

You feel safe to question the status quo and speak up

The Business Case for Getting This Right

70%

of the variance in team engagement is explained by the manager alone

Gallup, State of the American Manager

#1

Psychological safety was the single biggest factor separating high-performing teams from the rest

Google, Project Aristotle

69%

of employees say their manager affects their mental health as much as their spouse — more than their doctor

The Workforce Institute at UKG, 2023

Employee Wellness: More Than Physical Health

Wellbeing has several dimensions — and managers influence nearly all of them through everyday interactions.

Emotional

Feeling heard, valued, and able to manage stress

Social

Belonging, connection, and healthy team relationships

Professional

Growth, purpose, and a sense of progress at work

Physical

Sustainable workload, rest, and work-life boundaries

Financial

Fair pay, clarity, and confidence in job stability

Psychological

Feeling safe to speak up, ask, and be yourself

Part 2: Everyday Leadership Practices

How everyday leadership behaviors build trust, encourage open communication, and foster a healthy team

Building Trust in Everyday Interactions

Trust isn't built in one big moment — it's built (or eroded) in small ones, every day.

1

Follow through on commitments

If you say you'll do it, do it — or explain clearly why not

2

Admit your own mistakes

Model the vulnerability you want your team to show

3

Give credit generously

Recognize contributions publicly and specifically

4

Be consistent

Treat people fairly whether you're having a good day or a hard one

Encouraging Open Communication

How you react in the moment teaches your team whether it's really safe to speak up.

1 Ask open questions “What am I missing?” or “What’s your take?” invites real answers, not just agreement

2 Listen to understand, not to respond Pause before reacting. Reflect back what you heard before offering your view

3 Respond well to bad news How you react to the first mistake determines whether you hear about the next one

4 Normalize questions Say it explicitly: “There are no dumb questions on this team” — and mean it

What Psychological Safety Looks Like

LOW PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

- Mistakes are hidden until they become bigger problems
- Meetings are quiet; real conversations happen after, in private
- People agree in the room and disagree in the hallway
- Questions are seen as a sign someone isn't keeping up

HIGH PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

- ✓ Problems surface early, while they're still small and fixable
- ✓ People voice concerns and ideas openly, in the room
- ✓ Disagreement happens directly and respectfully
- ✓ Questions are welcomed as a sign of engagement

Balancing Individual, Team & Organizational Needs

Great managers hold all three in mind at once — rarely perfectly, but consciously.



Individual

Unique needs, strengths, and circumstances of each team member

Team

Dynamics, fairness, and consistency across the whole group

Organization

Policies, resources, and business goals you're accountable to

Part 3: Putting It Into Practice

Key Takeaways

1

Psychological safety is a performance driver, not a soft skill

It's the top predictor of team effectiveness — and it's built through daily behavior

2

You have more influence than almost anyone else

Managers shape engagement and mental health more than most people realize

3

Small, consistent behaviors matter most

Trust is built in how you respond to mistakes, questions, and bad news — every time

4

Balance is a practice, not a solved problem

You won't get individual, team, and organizational needs perfectly right — stay conscious of the trade-offs



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Building Safety, Strengthening Culture

Jennifer Hopp, SPHR, SHRM-CP, CDE

Director, Human Resources

MISSION

Our mission is to advance the highest standards of the practice of anesthesiology.

VISION

Our vision is to transform certification to shape the future of anesthesiology.

We embrace the diversity of our collective voices and continuously challenge the status quo to enhance the value of certification.

VALUES



Service

We demonstrate a commitment to service in everything we do, and we continually exhibit a customer service culture.



Reliability

We demonstrate dependability as individuals and employees for our own actions and their consequences; and for the performance of our duties and functions. We are trustworthy in all that we do.



Adaptability

We demonstrate flexibility in rapidly changing conditions. We do what it takes to adjust our approach and shift our priorities to meet the needs of our constituents.

CULTURAL COMMITMENTS



Care

We care for one another and all those we serve.



Respect

We lead with respect and celebrate our differences.



Collaboration

We learn from each other and share in our successes.

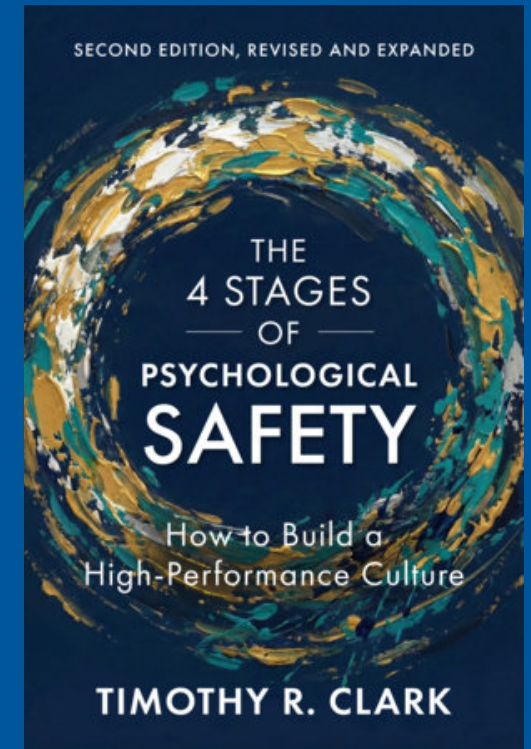
Building a Foundation of Safety

Dr. Timothy R. Clark

- Defines psychological safety in five words: **a culture of rewarded vulnerability**
- The behavioral mechanism — modeling and rewarding vulnerability

4 stages model

1. Inclusion safety
2. Learner safety
3. Contributor safety
4. Challenger safety



Inclusion & Belonging

Authenticity

- Dress code
- Religious beliefs
- Introversion vs. Extroversion
- Diversity

Accountability

- Values
- Cultural Commitments
- Code of Conduct

Connection

- ABA Ally
- Culture Committee
- Building Connections Committee

Accessibility

- Hybrid work, Flexible work options to provide support for all staff needs (ex. Caregiving, appointments, mental health, etc.)
- Accommodations
- Meeting Standards
- Care Leave (paid FMLA leave)

Learning & Development

- ABA Ally
- Manager Mentor
- Professional development budget
- Manager Training program
- Leadership development via CCL
- AI Literacy



Contributor

Recruitment

- Focus on skills and work experience
- Group panel interviews with group debrief
- Involve key stakeholders

Onboarding

- Structured process
- ABA Ally
- Executive introductions

Feedback channels

- Surveys (annual engagement, pulse checks, ad-hoc)
- Executive Director open office hours
- Musings with Michele
- Anonymous Feedback form
- Executive Director annual 360

Recognition

- Level Up program (peer to peer)
- Service Awards

Challenger

Staff Leadership Team

- Executive Team, Directors, Managers
- Feedback shared directly between leadership
- Proactive approach

Focus groups

- Staff grouping for input into new programs/policies
- Represent various departments and levels
- Invite positive and negative sentiments

Issue Escalation Framework

- Escalation path based on level of risk
- Shared accountability
- Transparency and awareness

Measured Results

Our 2026 Engagement Survey points to many of the conditions that support psychological safety.

Strong relationships

Employees report strong relationships with coworkers and a culture grounded in teamwork.

Respect & inclusion

Respect, valuing different backgrounds, and equal opportunity are clear cultural strengths.

A positive employee experience

Employees continue to value ABA's culture, benefits, engagement opportunities, and supportive environment.

Measured Results

89%

Coworkers have good working relationships

85%

ABA has a safe work environment

95%

People of all cultures/backgrounds are respected and valued

85%

ABA staff treat each other with respect

86%

ABA staff take the initiative to help each other when the need arises

80%

I can be my authentic self at the ABA

The opportunity is not “speak up more” alone—it is creating the conditions that make speaking up feel worthwhile and safe.

Psychological Safety in Everyday ABA Moments

When we're introducing change

- Explain the why—not just the what
- Invite questions and alternative perspectives
- Acknowledge what is still uncertain

When something goes wrong

- Focus first on learning and fixing
- Thank the person who surfaced the issue
- Separate the mistake from the person

When someone disagrees

- Treat disagreement as information
- Ask: “What am I missing?”
- Challenge the idea—not the person

When someone asks for help

- Make questions normal
- Avoid “you should already know” responses
- Recognize that asking early often prevents rework

The Shared Opportunity

As leaders & managers

- Invite dissenting perspectives
- Listen before defending or explaining
- Respond constructively to bad news
- Close the loop when concerns are raised
- Model that it is okay not to have every answer

As colleagues

- Speak up respectfully
- Ask questions and seek clarity
- Assume positive intent
- Make room for quieter voices
- Give and receive feedback
- Recognize that healthy disagreement can improve decisions

What is one small thing I can do to make it easier for someone else to speak up?



Psychological Safety in Remote Work

Paul Zobitz, ABPMR



From In-Person to Remote Work



Pre-Covid

- 22 Staff
- 95% lived near HQ
- 90% in-office full-time
- 10% remote

Today

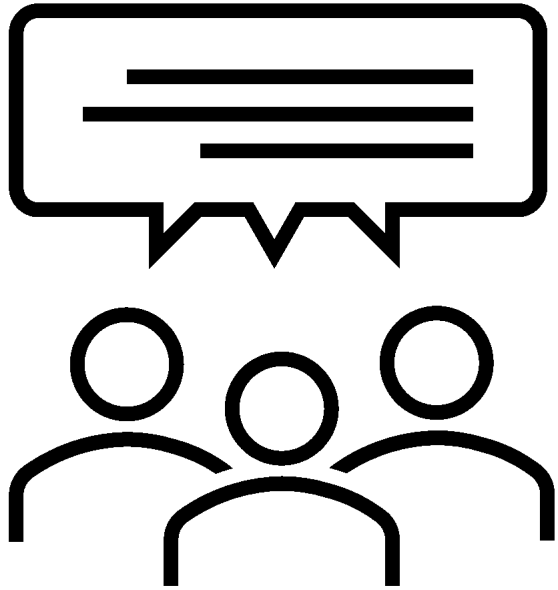
- 25 Staff
- 48% live near HQ
- 0% in-office full-time
- 16% hybrid
- 84% remote

Major Considerations

- **Communication channels**
- **Norms (cameras, calendar updates, etc.)**
- **Meeting types**
- **Routines/ritual changes**
- **Coming together**

Practical Tips

- **Communication, Communication, Communication**
- **Consider best communication channel**
- **Assume positive intent**
- **Respond thoughtfully (sometimes emojis aren't enough)**
- **Allow opportunities for connection**
- **Encourage sharing**



Q&A

Building Psychological Safety

Reflect with your table, then be ready to share one success.

1

TABLE DISCUSSION

5 MINUTES

Consider the climate at your organization.

Share one challenge and one success related to building psychological safety.

2

REPORT OUT

5 MINUTES

Each table: Share one success with the full group.



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